Chapter 9

The Tamsa Bird

SUMMARY. The god had married two women who were birds, the grey hornbill and the yellow-billed hornbill. He dug *g‖xaru* (Lapeirousia bainesii) roots, and filled a sack with them. The god was a person who did not share food with his wives, so he hung up the sack, pretending it was filled with sand. They all danced, and he secretly ate *g‖xaru* from the sack. He also prepared a long wooden paddle and laid it by. When they danced again, the god said he didn't want his wives to dance in front of him, but instead he wanted the tall woman sitting on the other side of the fire. The tall woman paid him no mind, but just kept on singing. Another woman came to dance in front of him, but he refused, calling again for the tall woman. Again she refused. Much later the tall woman, her bangles clinking, came and danced with him. They danced in parallel, and then sat down and turned away from and towards each other in turn. Then the god took up his long wooden paddle and beat her stomach and threw her down and she died. The dance split up and the god was alone, praising himself and saying, "This is how I do things!"

SPEAKER. *|Xoan N!a'an*

RECORDED. Kauri, Botswana, 1971

TRANSCRIBED BY. *Tsamkxao Fanni |Ui, Jafet Gcao Nqeni, G‡kao Martin |Kaece*

ha koh n|hui dshau tsaqn sa
he had married two women who
ju ku ko ha n|ui
people say that one of them

te,
(was,)
ha n|ui hin to'a he o ǂhamsa
one of them was the grey hornbill, Tockus nasutus
te ha hin to'a o ha, ee
and this one was the, yes
ha g!u ka gǂa'in, ha ku ko "tcaqri, tcaqri, tcaqri, tcaq'in, tcaq
her stomach was long, she said "(onomatop.)
tcaq'in, tcaq'in, tcaq'in, tcaq'intcaq'in"
(onomatop)
he khoe tcu he ha hin to'a
and was like the yellow-billed hornbill (Tockus flavirostris) here, that one
ee, tsi ho ha dshaua he o Ju|'hoandi he ju ku ko "hatce ce khoe to'a?"
yes, came and saw this woman here, a Ju|'hoan woman that people said "what was that there?"
"hatce ce ǁu ce hatce?"
"what again perched here is what?"
ǁu care...
perched facing...
te ǁxoasi
and naturally
te
and
ha gu gǁxaru, te gu gǁxaru, te gu gǁxaru te
he dug gǁxaru (roots of Lapeirousia bainesii), and dug gǁxaru, and dug gǁxaru and
sa ka n|aisi can khoe sa hinke ha gu
whose bulbs were this big, he dug
te gu te
and dug and
tsau
got up
ǁ'aha te |'u g!a'in !oma
and he filled up the sack
khama jua |oa 'm |xoa ha dshausin he |oa 'm |xoa ju
because he was a person who did not eat with his wives, he didn't eat with people
ha ku g|ae ǁu ka
he went and hung it up
"mtsa nǂhao ǁkae
"let us two walk together
te tse ku djxani ka tcxai"
and then dance a dance"
mm
yes

te dshau he
and this woman
dshaua to'a, kohm, ǀoe tsi gǀae
that woman, for sure, just came up
g‖xaru tse taa koe
the g‖xaru itself came to lie like this
ha nǀhui ka n!ani te ‖'a te
he took three of them and then
tsau te !'un kxa
stood up and picked up handfuls of sand
kxa sa ka hin ke ha !'un te
this sand here he picked up by handfuls and
ǀ'u ha !oma, ǀ'u ha !oma, ǀ'u ha !oma
put it into the bag, put it into the bag, put it into the bag
n‖a te ko ha g‖xaru te ha nǀhui ka g‖xaru n!ani
mentioned the g‖xaru and took three g‖xaru
te ǀ'ua khoe nǀui
and put them somewhere else
te ǂaeh ku djxani, ǂaeh te si ge'e
and went home and danced, went home and they sang
ha djxani te djxani te tsi !'an ko ha ni gu ka g‖xaru nǀang 'm te
he danced and danced and went forward and tried to take the g‖xaru and eat and
te coe ka n!ani te 'm
and took out three and ate them
te ko ha te nǀhui ka kxa
and said he had pulled out sand
te kua gu ‖'a !aihnǀ'o he kahin to'a he o ha ga
and quickly took that wooden paddle there of his
te
and
ǂaeh cu te
went back and lay down and
" zain, zain, zain
(sings) onomatop
zain, zain, zain
(onomatop)
zain, zain, zain, zain, zain, zain"
(onomatop.)"
ka ha
and then he
ha dshau nǀui
another woman

ǂhom ka
ended it (the song)
ka ha dshau n|ui ǂhom ka ǁ'aka ha ka n|ang ka ku
and then another woman ended it and she sat and was
tsi ǂaeha ha ka ha ko "|'aeqe"
going to come to him but he said "(onomatop)"
"mi ǁa'ike |oa kxoa ju sa he
"today I don't want these people
te ku kxoa dshaua g|ae to'a n|ang
but I want that woman sitting on the other side over there
te gǂa'in
who is tall
mi m ku kxoa ǁ'a dshaua"
I want that woman"
ka ǁ'a dshaua |oe n!un ka ku ge'e
and that woman just stood and was singing
ka
and
ka
and
ka
and
ka si !hun ǁ'a tzia
and they killed (ended) that song
ka ce ka gu tsau
and then began again
ka ha ǂaeh nǂhao ka cu ka du
and then he went and dropped down and lay down and was doing
ǁ'a tca
that
ka dshau n|ui g|ai ka tsi ǂaeha
and another woman came out and came up to him
ka tsi ǂaeh ku n|amm
and came up and danced before him
te ha ko "|'hain
and he said "(onomatop.lisping speech)
"|'hain te |xau sa dshau...
"(onomatop. and refuse that woman (lisping speech)...
dshau sa he ǁa'ike ku ǂaeha mi he
these women who today are coming to me....
dshau u he, mi tia kxoa dshaua u he ka ka ha n|amm mi"
that woman over there, I myself want that woman over there to dance in front of me"

ha koe n‖ae
he thus spoke
ha
he
te si ǀoe ǀoa ko te ku ko te ha ku koe n‖ae te
but they just didn't say (anything)and they just did and he thus said
!hun ‖'a tzia
(they) killed that song
te
and
te ǀoe ku koe djxani
and just danced like this
te ku
and was
dshausi ku nǀamm ha
women were dancing in front of him
ha ku !xau
he refused
te ‖'a dshaua
and that woman
!aihn te tsi ǂaeha
was clinking (bangles) and came up to him
te sa ǂaroa khoe te khuin ǀ'ae sa u g!hooa te ha
and they two danced parallel to each other and thus they went and sat and he
ha ku mania ha ǀ'ae ko ha dshau, ka ku mani ha ǀ'ae, ka dshau ku mani haǀ'ae
he turned himself toward the woman, and turned back, and then the woman turned her
ǀ'ae ko ha ka ha ku mania ha ǀ'ae ko ha dshau
self towards him and then he turned himself toward the woman
te ha nǀa ‖ae ‖'a !aihnǀ'oa, ha kua ko " ǂhoan" ko ha tchinǀho
and he certainly held that wooden paddle, and quickly went "(onomatop.)" on her midriff
te n!o'an nǂhao
threw her down
te !ai
and (she) died
aie, te ka tcxai ka, ju ka, ka tcxai ka saraa khoe ko khuin to'a
mother, and the dance then, people then, the dance then split up there
mm
yes
te ju kxae, ju ka
and people had, people had
gǀae te ha kare ha ǀ'ae te ko
gone and he praised himself and said

"ǀ'haqn ǀ'haqn tia koe"
"(onomatop) myself thus"
tca tcisa ǁ'a ǁ'aiha n!a'an nǁaahn du
88 *that which, things that that old god long ago did*
o tcisa ju !ae nǁaahn ku nǁae he mi ku tsa'a
they're the things the old people long ago told that I heard
mm
90 *yes*